Microsoft Clarity vs Our Intent Pipeline

How Clarity's User Intent metric works, and how close our scoring is to it. Written in plain language.

1. How Clarity decides intent

Clarity puts every session into **Low, Medium or High** intent. Microsoft says it uses a combination of **session length, clicks and scrolls, and whether the visitor completed key smart events**. A *smart event* is an action the site owner marks as valuable, such as a purchase or a signup.

Bucket	What Clarity says
Low	Under 5 seconds on the site, or a longer stay with no clicks or scrolls.
Medium	Over 5 seconds with some interaction: clicks, scrolls, or a minimal number of smart events.
High	Over 5 seconds with active interaction: clicks and key smart events.

What Microsoft does not say. The only number it gives is the 5-second cut-off. It does not publish a formula, the weight of each signal, what counts as a "minimal" smart event, or exactly how Medium is separated from High. So any comparison is approximate.

Clarity also tracks **frustration signals**: rage clicks, dead clicks, excessive scrolling and quick backs. These are separate metrics. From what I found, they are not inputs to the intent bucket.

2. How our pipeline decides intent

Each closed session gets a score from 0 to 100, then a bucket. Full detail is in `INTENT_SCORING_LOGIC.pdf`.

- **Points** for product views (11 each, up to 4), useful clicks (2.2, up to 12), minutes on site (4.5, up to 6), scrolls (1.8, up to 8) and pages viewed (1.5, up to 6).
- **Penalties:** bounce -20 (2 or fewer events, or under 5 seconds) and struggle -12 (many dead clicks).
- **Page-type multiplier** from 0.70 to 1.15, based on how close to buying the visitor got.
- **Buckets** from each brand's own percentiles: bottom 35% Low, next 37% Medium, top 28% High.
- **Override:** checkout, add-to-cart or a checkout page forces the operational bucket to High.
- **Per visitor:** the best-scoring session.

3. Side by side

Topic	Microsoft Clarity	Our pipeline
Output	Low / Medium / High per session	0-100 score, plus Low / Medium / High, per session and per visitor
Time on site	5-second cut-off for Low	Up to 27 points for minutes; -20 bounce penalty under 5 seconds
Clicks and scrolls	Counted as engagement	Counted with caps and weights
Key actions	Site-owner-defined smart events	Fixed: product views, checkout, add-to-cart
Frustration (dead clicks)	Separate metric	Penalty of -12 inside the score
Bucket cut-offs	Rule-based, fixed	Percentiles of each brand's own traffic (fixed 25 / 55 if under 500 sessions)
Bots	Part of the wider product	Excluded from scoring
Buying proximity	Not described	Page-type multiplier and checkout / cart override

4. How close are we?

Close in spirit. Both use time, clicks and scrolls, and both end in Low / Medium / High. Both treat very short visits as low intent (5 seconds in both). Both look at dead clicks as a frustration signal.

We go further in these ways:

- A 0-100 score, not just a label.
- Weight on how close the visitor got to buying (product views, checkout, cart).
- Buckets that adapt to each brand's own traffic, so a quiet brand still shows a High group.
- A visitor-level intent, not only per session.

Clarity does one thing we do not: the site owner chooses the smart events. Ours are hard-coded, so a brand cannot say "this action matters to us".

Expect differences in the numbers. Clarity's labels follow fixed rules. Ours depend on the day's percentiles, so the same session can be Medium in one and High in the other. Our Low roughly matches Clarity's Low. Our checkout / cart override plays the role of Clarity's key smart events, but only approximately.

5. If you want to move closer

- **Brand-configurable smart events**: let each brand list the actions that count as key. This is the one real gap.
- Keep the 5-second rule as it is; the bounce penalty already covers it.
- Optionally publish a simple rule-based label next to our percentile bucket, so the two can be compared directly.

Sources

- Microsoft Clarity blog, User Intent metric: https://clarity.microsoft.com/blog/user-intent-metric-understand-engagement-at-a-glance/
- Microsoft Learn, Clarity semantic metrics: https://learn.microsoft.com/da-dk/clarity/semantic-metrics

- ppc.land summary (seen in search results only; the page could not be opened): https://ppc.land/microsoft-clarity-unveils-user-intent-metrics/